2 Television

In this unit you will find out:

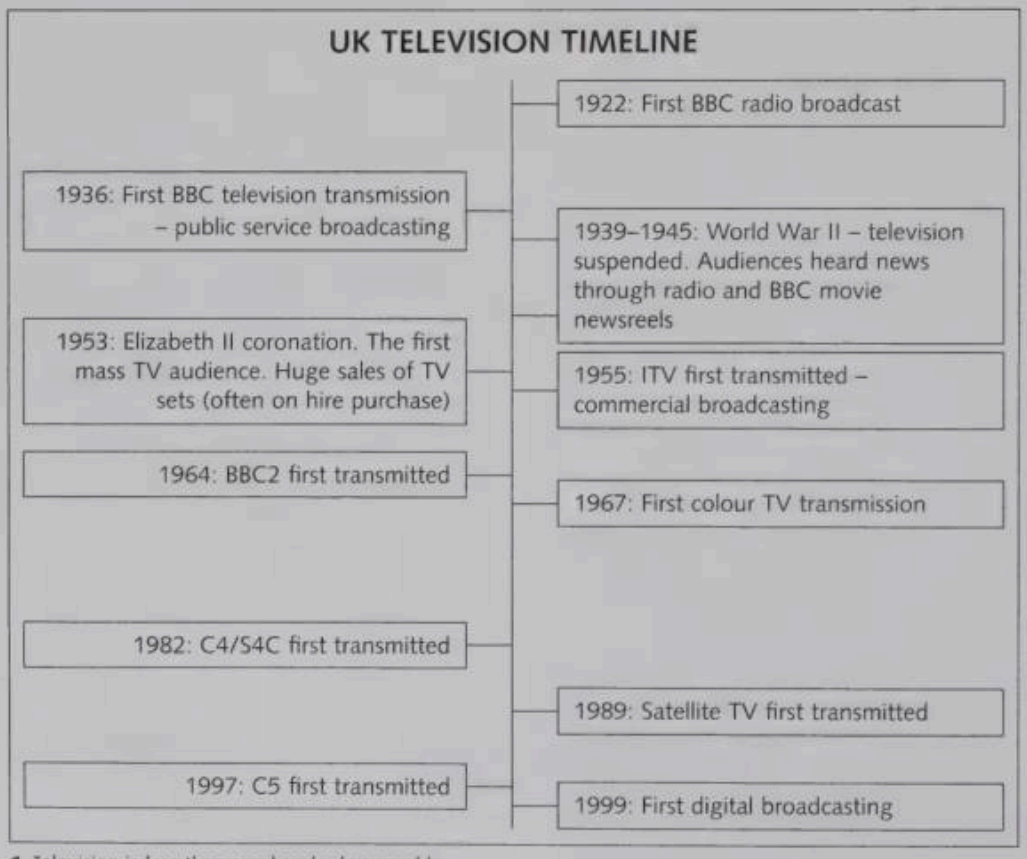
- how different television genres use codes and presentational devices to convey meaning
- how television attracts, retains and is used by its audience
- how the way a channel is funded affects the programmes that it shows
- how television programmes represent groups and individuals as stereotypes, and how these stereotypes change over time.

TALKING POINT

- When, how much and under what circumstances do you watch television?
- What would you miss most if you had to spend three months without it?

Television – a brief history

Did you find it hard to imagine life without television? Yet just sixty years ago it was unusual for a family to have even one black-and-white television set, let alone a colour, widescreen, surround-sound system in the living room and possibly another one in your bedroom! To get a good idea of the major developments in television history, look at the timeline in **1**.



1 Television is less than one hundred years old

KEY TERMS

Commercial broadcaster a channel funded by money from advertising

Peak time the hours between 6.00pm and 10.30pm when most people are watching television so that viewing figures are at their highest

Public service broadcaster a channel funded by a licence fee that has to provide a choice of programmes to appeal to all social groups

When the BBC first began transmitting radio programmes in the 1920s and television in the 1930s, it was as a **public service broadcaster.** This means that, in return for the payment of a licence fee, the BBC will provide viewers with a service of programmes that are guaranteed to 'inform, educate and entertain' and to appeal to as wide an audience as possible (this is known as the *public service remit*).

When ITV first began transmitting television programmes in the 1950s it was as a **commercial broadcaster** whose programmes are funded by advertising revenue. Independent TV channels are paid money in return for time slots that advertisers use to promote their products. Such time slots vary in price depending on whether they are during **peak time** (6.00pm to 10.30pm) or not. This is the time of day when audiences are at their greatest.

ACTIVITY 1

1 Conduct a class survey to find out which channels you watch most frequently. Each choose your top three favourites out of the following channels and award three marks to the first choice, two to the second and one to the third. Then add up the class marks for each channel.

- BBC1
- BBC2
- ITV1
- Channel 4/S4C
- Five
- Sky One
- Sky Sports channels
- Music channels
- Movie channels
- E4

2 Look at the television schedule for any day of the week in a TV listings magazine. Count up how many programmes on BBC1 and BBC2 are informative, educational and/or entertaining.

3 Now look at the programmes that are on the other channels listed above during peak time. Can you identify any types of programmes which are especially popular during peak time?

4 Discuss as a class or in small groups whether or not the BBC should be allowed to continue charging a licence fee. Use information from this activity and the class survey.

What do you think would happen to viewing choices if every channel was funded by advertising revenue? Advertisers are most interested in buying time slots around or during peak-time programmes, when most people are watching. This pressurises commercial broadcasting channels into producing more and more of the types of programmes that are most popular. Does this necessarily lead to quality programmes?



Television production

Television programmes are either made directly by television companies, or commissioned from smaller freelance companies. What are the factors that contribute to the making of successful programmes? Look at the list in box **2** – which components do you think are the most important?

A Key roles

- *Executive Producer* – arranges finance and oversees the whole project, including editorial decisions.
- *Producer/Director* – is responsible for the setting up and shooting of every scene.
- *Scriptwriter* – writes the script for the programme; this could be from an original idea or an adaptation.
- *Researcher* – ensures all details of location, sets, props and costume are appropriate and accurate for the style and time period of the programme.
- *Production Assistant* – looks after all administration, including scripts and running orders.
- *Locations Manager* – finds locations where a programme can be shot. Sometimes this will be a studio, but often a 'real' location such as a particular style of house or street must be found.
- *Camera Operator* – responsible for setting up every shot in a scene. This may involve working with other operators for techniques such as shot reverse shot.
- *Lighting Engineer* – works with Director and Camera Operator to ensure correct and safe lighting is provided on location or in the studio.
- *Sound Engineer* – ensures that different sound sources in a scene are balanced and that external factors such as wind do not interfere.
- *Editor* – takes the 'raw footage' shot each day and edits it into a sequence of scenes that tell the story. This can also involve adding music, fades and dissolves.
- *Costume Designer* – creates a set of costumes which are appropriate to the style and setting of the programme.
- *Make-up Artist* – ensures actors look right for their part; this can involve changing an actor in some way, e.g. by giving them realistic injuries in a medical drama.
- *Set Designer* – designs and builds sets that are appropriate to the style and setting of the programme.
- *Actors/Performers* – create believable characters.

B Stages of production

- *Pre-Production* – Ideas, bids for finance, storyboards, scriptwriting, planning and designing, set construction, casting, rehearsals.
- *Production* – Shooting in purpose-built sets or in outside locations.
- *Post-Production* – Editing, sound dubbing, credits, marketing and promotion, focus groups, trailers, articles and features.

2 Components of a TV production

KEY TERM

Title sequence a series of shots and music or graphics that appear at the start of a programme

The answer, of course, is that they are all important at different times and in different ways. Ultimately, it is the performance in front of the camera which attracts and keeps audiences, but for those performances to be outstanding, the team behind the camera need to have done their specialist jobs first.

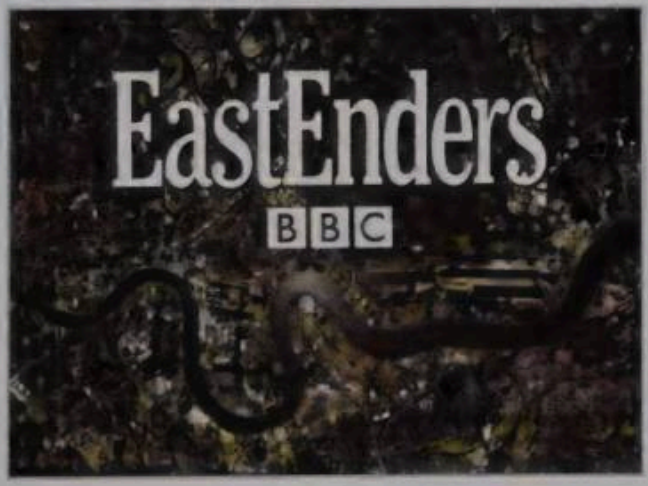
A television production is a complex task, and planning is absolutely vital. However, some things are unpredictable, no matter how good the plan.

- Multiple takes are often needed to 'get it right' in front of the camera – look at programmes which are about moments when actors do not get it right.
- Live audiences: unpredictability on the part of guests and audiences and having to manage large numbers.
- The weather: some programmes have to be cancelled due to poor weather conditions, while others have to be suspended until weather conditions are right – it is not always possible to create a sunny day.
- Illness or scandal: a key character or presenter may be too ill to appear or involved in some public scandal.
- Special effects and stunts do not always go to plan.

Skill and teamwork are needed to get over these problems as they arise. Summer scenes for the *X-Files* were filmed in snowy Vancouver by blowing the snow off the grass first.

Title sequences

The language of the moving image text is a complex mixture of codes and messages that audiences are expert at reading and understanding. A great way to find out about the ways moving image texts communicate with audiences is by examining **title sequences**, which are highly crafted short texts.





3 Images from the title sequence of *EastEnders*

Look at the shots in **3** from the title sequence of *EastEnders*. What clues do they give you about the programme? You can see some ideas in the table on the next page – can you add any to the list?

What you can see	What you can work out about the programme
The River Thames	It is set in London.
The Millennium Dome at Greenwich	It is set in the present, probably near Limehouse Reach.
The title is in big, bold writing.	It is called EastEnders.
The second image is in more close-up than the first.	The programme will focus on a small part of London.

If you are able to watch the opening, you will be able to pick out many more points. For example:

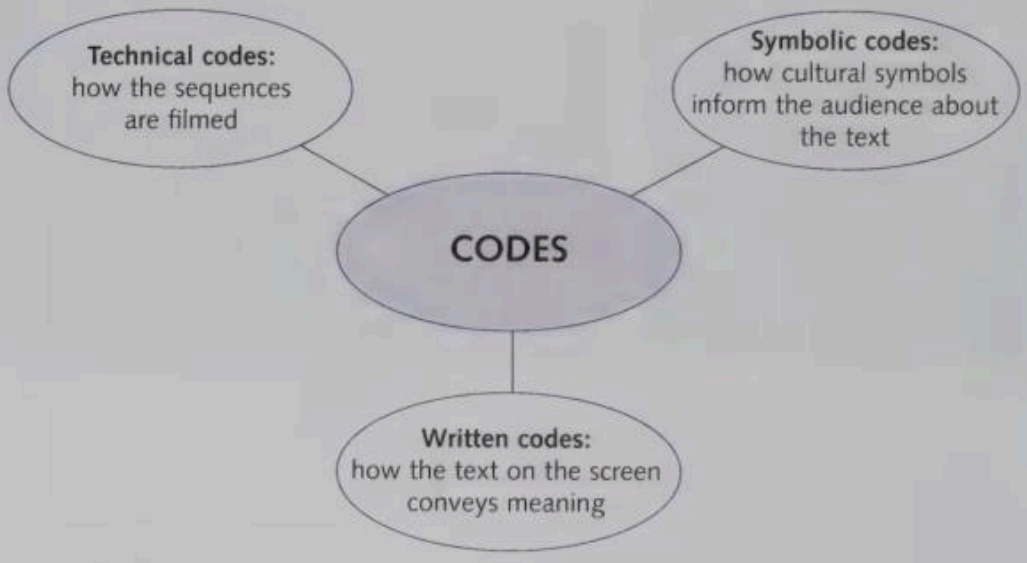
- The camera looks down on the map and rotates just before the title comes up, giving the viewer a different view of the river and its surroundings.
- The title emerges from the map just as the private lives of the characters emerge from their East End homes in the storylines for the programme.

ACTIVITY 2

Watch the title sequence of *Coronation Street*. Pick out the features that give you clues about the programme and put them in a table like the one for *EastEnders*.

Did the *EastEnders* title sequence tell you anything about the characters in the series? You may be surprised that no characters appear, but producers of title sequences often avoid showing people because then the sequence has to be changed much more often as characters join and leave the cast. The title sequence of *Neighbours*, for example, includes characters and has to be changed regularly. Look back at **3**: why do you think that the *EastEnders* sequence had to be changed in about 2000?

One way to approach the analysis of texts such as title sequences is to break down the task into three distinct areas, each of which focuses on a different type of code (see the diagram in **4**).



4 Types of codes

TIP

Spider diagrams are a quick and clear way to show the examiner what you know.

KEY TERMS

Dissolve when one screen image fades into another

Fade when the screen image gradually disappears

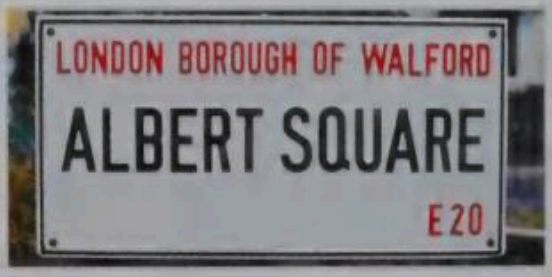
Transition moving from one screen image to another

Wipe when one screen image appears to wipe away another

Technical codes

Technical codes include any of the technical processes used to create the text. Features to look for include:

- *Types of shot*, e.g. establishing shots. These may be of famous landmarks, such as the Millennium Dome, that indicate where events take place, or of signs to show where they are (see **5**) or what their function is, e.g. a sign saying Grange Hill School.



5 This establishing shot shows the location of *EastEnders*

- The **transitions** between shots, such as **fades**, **wipes**, **dissolves** and others.
- The *angle of the shot:* low angles make the subject seem larger and more imposing; high angles have the reverse effect.
- *Camera movements* such as *zooming in* on a subject or *tracking shots*, where the camera follows alongside the subject. This type of shot gets its name from the tracks that are put down so that the camera moves smoothly (**6**).



6 A camera recording a tracking shot